SPARTACUS

For many years, the name of the Thracian slave Spartacus struck fear into the hearts of the Roman people. It served to remind them of the danger that constantly menaced the continued existence of their state - the danger of an uprising of the enormous slave population, which might destroy the Roman nation. Scholars have calculated that in ancient Italy the slaves outnumbered the free citizens 3 to 1. If these slaves, who resented the brutal treatment they received as household and plantation labourers, had succeeded in uniting under capable leadership, no armies could have withstood them. There were many slave uprisings in the history of Rome, but the most formidable was that headed by Spartacus in 73 BC. After escaping from the school of gladiators at Capua, he fled to Mount Vesuvius, where he collected an army of runaway slaves like himself. For two years he terrorized Italy, defeating army after army sent against him from Rome. The insurrection was finally crushed by the Roman commander Marcus Licinius Crassus. Spartacus and 6,000 of his followers were slain.

EXERCISE 1: Find words or phrases in the passage which mean the same as:

COLUMN A **COLUMN B**

a) a person who is owned by another person and has to work for him .....

b) produce feelings of terror in someone *(phrase)* .....

c) continually; always .....

d) threaten; bring danger to .....

e) work out; make a firm guess about something .....

f) be larger in number .....

g) the people of a nation .....

h) feel angry and bitter about .....

i) rough and cruel .....

j) people who do the work on a large farm *(two words)* .....

k) having ability; effective .....

l) resist; remain unharmed .....

m) hard to overcome; strong and powerful .....

n) escaped [adjective] .....

o) frighten people by using violence .....

p) rebellion; revolt .....

q) be destroyed; be finished off .....

r) be killed .....

EXERCISE 2: Choose the correct answer according to the passage.

1. Spartacus's name made the Romans afraid because. . . . . .

A) he was a very aggressive and dangerous man
B) his attitude towards other slaves was brutal
C) he could get support from other nations
D) he was a symbol of the danger of a slave rebellion
E) he was supported by a number of officers in the Roman army

2. According to scholars, in ancient Italy, ...

A) the slave population was almost as big as that of Roman citizens
B) every family owned at least three slaves
C) there were more slaves than free citizens
D) some of the slaves were specially educated
E) slaves sometimes overthrew their masters

3. The author believes that a unity of slaves headed by a capable leader. . . . . .

A) played a major role in battles against Roman forces
B) would have been strong enough to beat any army
C) helped Spartacus win the battle at Mount Vesuvius
D) would increase production on plantations
E) would still find it extremely hard to resist experienced Roman soldiers

EXERCISE 3." Complete the sentences by selecting words from Column B in EXERCISE 1.

1. I wasn't too surprised to learn that the girls……the boys in the ballet class by 10 to 1.
2. Beginning in the 13th century, the Italian cities built……merchant fleets, acquired islands and coastal territories as commercial bases, and soon established a rich trade in spices, indigo, and other Eastern goods.
3. Karen really……the fact that her male colleagues are doing the same job as her but earning more.
4. You don't need to worry about Molly - she's quite……of looking after herself.
5. Steve……that he would be able to afford a decent holiday if he managed to save about £15 a week.